

# Home Alone

## Separation Anxiety in Dogs *Analysis, Treatment and Protocols*

By Mike Wombacher



415-420-4768

[mwdoggonegood@gmail.com](mailto:mwdoggonegood@gmail.com)

# Separation Anxiety

## Analysis, Treatment and Protocols

### Overview

In March, 2020 the world changed. With only a few days' notice, we were plunged into isolation. For nearly two years. Coping was hard. And wore many faces. But it also provided a few new opportunities. Dog ownership was one.

During the pandemic, puppy ownership exploded. People were home and puppies filled a gap. Then they grew up. And the pandemic ended. People were home less and less and now adult dogs, weaned on constant companionship, were expected to deal with at least some time on their own. It didn't go well. Many were returned to breeders or turned into shelters.

Those owners not so quick to give up turned to day care and boarding facilities to bridge the gap of their absences. With mixed results.

One of the hats that I wear is that I'm training director at [Alpha Dog Lodging](#) in Mill Valley, where I designed and run both the boarding/training and service dog training programs. In that role, I've seen directly the difficulty many dogs have not only being away from their owners, even with other dogs around, but being alone in the facility during the structured play breaks we impose during the day to avoid overstimulation.

This problem became so pronounced that at one point we were declining fifty percent

of applicants because separation from their owners so distressed them that they could not settle sufficiently to enjoy themselves in the company of other dogs. Never mind alone.

That's when I decided to establish some protocols to help dogs and owners overcome this very difficult emotional hurdle. And to help ourselves capture some of the income we were forced to leave on the table. This little book is the outcome of that effort.

Of course, there's nothing new about separation anxiety. I saw plenty of it during my thirty years of private training. What's new is the scope of the problem. In what follows, I'll attempt to take as deep a dive as possible into this issue as concisely as possible.

We'll begin by looking at symptoms and attempting to assess whether these are a result of true separation anxiety or some other cause.

We'll also address the issue, whatever its cause, by assessing its level of intensity and begin laying out a range of options that are short of the full-on separation anxiety protocols for severe cases outlined in the second half of this booklet.

Throughout this process I'll do my best to limit technical language, though I'll provide sufficient context for various training protocols to help you understand the thinking that's gone into them. By the end of it, you should have a solid sense of the framework of this approach and a pretty good idea of which part of it would be most helpful to you. From there you can either put together a treatment program on your own or work with us at [Alpha Dog](#) to help you along that path.

**Let's get started.**





# What is separation anxiety?

## And Does your Dog Have it?

Let me begin by saying that separation anxiety is one of the most difficult training problems to resolve reliably. Hands down! Many trainers won't even touch it for fear of failure and blame from the client. I understand. I've been there.

That said, not everything that dog owners and even dog professionals are quick to identify as separation anxiety is actually that, but rather something else. This is not a small point since how we label the behavior is going to determine our responses. And we have to be careful in choosing them. So, let's go in slowly.

My own first question when someone approaches me about their dog's separation anxiety is whether the quality of their barking and whining when being left alone seems more internally or externally focused.

True separation anxiety is basically a panic attack and many of the dog's problematic behaviors are designed to help relieve the anxious state. Anyone who's ever had a panic attack will completely understand. The behavioral responses aren't necessarily meant to get others to do as you wish or even help, but to find a way to self-soothe and mitigate the miserable state. More on this later.

What makes analyzing the issue of separation anxiety tricky is that many dogs display all kinds of problematic behaviors upon their owner's departure. But they're not necessarily an indicator of true

separation anxiety. They more mimic it. My trainers at [Alpha Dog Lodging](#) in Mill Valley often refer to this as an expression of FOMO – fear of missing out. While not completely accurate, it's not inaccurate either. In fact, it captures the difference nicely.

If the behavior has the quality of 'damnit, let me out of here' or the temper tantrum of a five-year-old child, then the 'separation anxiety' may, in fact, be more of an expression of FOMO – the frustration over being left alone and not getting what they want. There's a huge difference between frustration and anxiety. Regarding the former, dogs have to learn to exercise both emotional and physical impulse control as well as being given appropriate outlets for natural behaviors.

*Behaviors often reported as expressions separation anxiety include barking and howling, destruction, inappropriate elimination and being a 'Velcro dog'*

Behaviors often reported as expressions separation anxiety include barking and howling, destruction, inappropriate elimination and being a 'Velcro dog' who shadows their owners' every move. While all of these certainly can be indicators of true

separation anxiety, they aren't necessarily. Let's take a look.

If you have a dog who barks and howls when you leave you might consider checking if there are contributory factors at work here like noises in the street or at the door, other dogs barking in the distance, squirrels dashing around in the foliage just outside the window and so on. Your dog may also simply be bored, an issue to which we'll return shortly. And she may have learned that demand barking in other contexts has worked and decide to try it here.

If your dog is being destructive by tearing up furniture and rugs and digging at the floors and walls, once again, your dog may be bored. If she is, these behaviors not only relieve boredom, they're also self-reinforcing. In other words, they're fun and reinforce themselves. No further positives needed to make the behavior worse and worse. Or, if you've got a pup, perhaps she's trying to soothe sore gums. Are you leaving a nice variety of killer chewies and interactive toys lying around? If not, start. More on this in a moment. Other possible drivers of destruction can include things like nearby rodents that your dog is trying to root out, noise and storm phobias or even the onset of old age. Take an inventory and explore the possibilities.

If your dog is having potty accidents when you leave, ask yourself if, perhaps, they're not as housetrained as you think. Or maybe you've left them too long. Or paper trained them and never broken the habit. Or your dog just might have eaten something icky and couldn't help it. Or perhaps free-feeding is contributing.

Maybe there are other medical issues, including those that might arise with older age or the introduction of some kinds of medication. Think it through a little before drawing too many conclusions about separation anxiety.

*If none of these symptoms seem to be drivers of your dog's issues, then consider the possibility that it's a simple intolerance of frustration.*

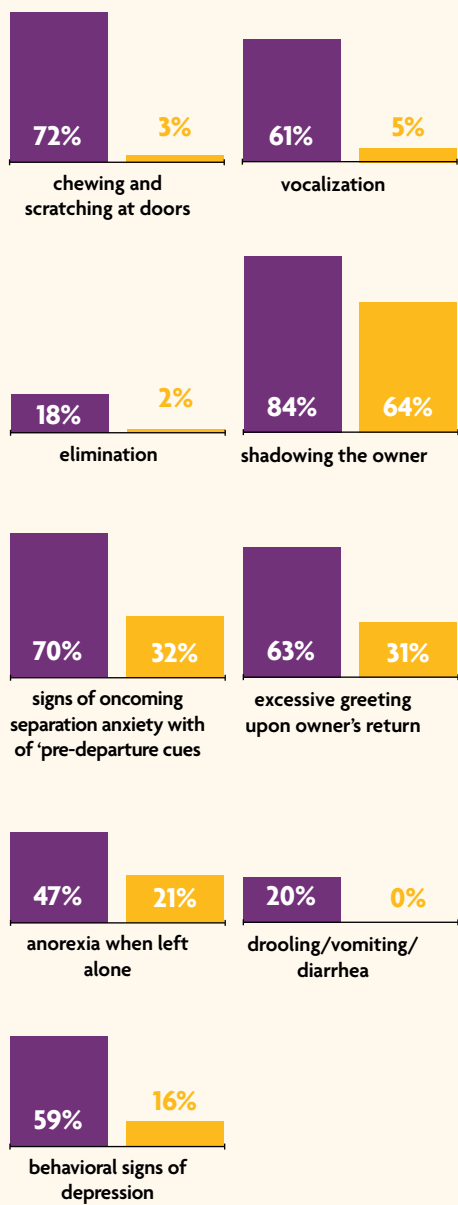
If none of these seem to be drivers of your dog's issues, then consider the possibility that it's a simple intolerance of frustration. They're not so much freaked out about being left alone as about not getting what they want. I often tell clients that if you had to net dog training out to single core principle around which everything else is organized, it would be teaching them to exercise impulse control and check in with you, at least when it comes to things that matter. Again, more in a moment.

Now, let's turn our attention to what separation anxiety actually is. The key piece to understand is that true separation anxiety has the qualities of any other anxiety or panic attack. There are very strong internal emotions that overwhelm your dog with terror. And your dog is trying to find relief. What can be confusing is that often the ways that your dog will try to find relief is by doing all the things just described.

A study done some years ago analyzing risk factors indicating separation anxiety compared two groups of dogs. The first had significant issues with separation anxiety. The second did not. The findings were interesting and broken out by behavior. The numbers represent percentages. The first number represents the percentage of dogs with separation anxiety that displayed the behavior and the second number represents the percent of dogs without separation anxiety that displayed the same behavior. For instance, in the case of destructive behavior like chewing and scratching at doors, 72% were dogs with separation



## Behaviors of dogs with separation anxiety compared to dogs that do not



Behaviors of dogs with separation anxiety  
 Behaviors of dogs who do not have separation anxiety

The first number represents the percentage of dogs with separation anxiety that displayed the behavior and the second number represents the percent of dogs without separation anxiety that displayed the same behavior.

anxiety displayed it while only 3% of dogs without it did. The remaining percentages didn't display the behavior at all.

Here's the rest of the list: vocalization – 61%/5%; elimination – 18%/2%; shadowing the owner – 84%/64% (obviously some overlap here); signs of oncoming separation anxiety with the introduction of 'pre-departure cues' (more later) – 70%/32%; excessive greeting upon owner's return – 63%/31%; anorexia when left alone (dog won't touch treats) – 47%/21%; drooling/vomiting/diarrhea 20%/0%; and behavioral signs of depression – 59%/16%.

It's easy to see how confusing it can be to initially determine whether our dog is suffering from separation anxiety or something else, including simple boredom.

With respect to this latter point, one way one might be able to tell the difference between boredom driven behaviors and anxiety driven behaviors is this: when barking or chewing or other destructive behaviors arise as a function of boredom, your dog will usually quit after a while.

When those behaviors are driven by anxiety, she will generally not quit because the unwanted behaviors often act as a mild sedative by releasing neurochemicals that help soothe the anxiety. In other words, the behaviors are self-reinforcing because they help your dog feel better. So, the key difference between behaviors driven by boredom and those driven by anxiety is persistence.

Bearing all this in mind, let's take a quick look at some other indicators that your dog may be struggling with separation anxiety. Note that these are not so much things that your dog is doing to or in the environment, but

rather physiological expressions of their fraught inner state. In addition to those already mentioned, they can include, in no particular order:

- **Avoiding eye contact**
- **Blinking or squinting**
- **Dilated pupils**
- **Repeated visual scanning**
- **'Whale Eye' or staring with mouth pursed forward**
- **Mouth closed tightly/pulled back**
- **Overly "Excited" whiskers**
- **Trembling or shaking**
- **Cowering**
- **Nose and lip licking**
- **Yawning**
- **Lifting paw**
- **Pacing, panting and hyper-vigilance.**
- **Escape attempts**
- **Furrowed Brows**
- **Freezing or walking slowly**
- **Nipping to keep you from leaving.**
- **Startling easily**
- **Hiding**
- **Drooling and/or vomiting**
- **General lethargy**
- **Self-mutilation, including as excessive grooming/licking.**
- **Sweaty paws**
- **Anal sac expression**
- **Increased heart rate**

This brings us to the two next steps: trying to figure out what's driving your dog's behavior and assessing how severe it is. Understanding this will help us develop the right approach for resolution. And can be tricky because, as we've just seen, there's some overlap in behaviors displayed by dogs that are often evaluated as separation anxiety..... and will often require some trial and error.

**This brings up a difficult topic.**

# On Aversive Control

Perhaps the most contentious area in the dog training world today revolves around the question of ‘aversive control.’ Aversive control is the use of anything your dog dislikes to help control unwanted behaviors. That includes things like squirt bottles, loud noises designed to startle and interrupt as well as similar measures meant to discourage unwanted behaviors.

A significant portion of today’s training world refuses to use any form of aversive control for any reason whatsoever. It’s always wrong in principle, they argue. Then take it further by claiming that squirting a dog with a water bottle is the same thing as kicking it across the room. Not kidding! They’ll then add the claim that all kinds of science backs them up and conclude that anyone who ever uses any form of aversive control is a soulless sociopath who enjoys hurting dogs. Again, not kidding.

This isn’t the place for an in-depth discussion of this issue (I have another book on this topic awaiting publication). But a few things should be noted. The claim that there’s some widespread consensus around the issue of aversive control is simply false. It’s just that the people who advocate this position only publicize those studies, usually done by people from the same camp, that support their view. When subsequent studies come out highlighting the shortcomings of their findings, they’re completely disregarded. Then they beat everyone else over the head with their ‘findings’ after lacing them with loads of sanctimony.

The problem is that they’re taking tools off the table in principle and thus often shortchanging clients and their dogs by not using things that actually would work, thereby dragging the training process along forever.

The other problem is that in some instances they’re right – aversive control shouldn’t play a role in training. The hard part is telling the difference.

My own approach hews to the so-called LIMA principles. LIMA stands for ‘least intrusive, minimally aversive.’ It implies common sense, not sanctimony. These guidelines respect the fact that in some situations a degree of aversive control is called for in order to initially suppress a problem behavior while new, more desirable behaviors can be developed through heavy doses of positive reinforcement. The question then becomes what degree and what kind? The answer is, the least intrusive, minimally aversive.

The thing to know here is that aversive control doesn’t have to be painful or terrifying. It just needs to be sufficiently annoying to your dog that she prefers not to have it happen again. When used in conjunction with massive amounts of positive reinforcement, aversive control quickly becomes self-extinguishing. Soon, the need for it disappears altogether.

In the context of separation issues, the only form of aversive control would be loud, startling noises, sprays of some kind, or perhaps a vibration on a collar. Nothing more than that. Which brings us to the next issue: when to use it.

And that returns us to the distinction made above. Are your dog’s problematic behaviors driven by some kind of FOMO ‘separation anxiety’ or the ‘panic attack’ variety, which is the real deal and much more complicated? With dogs suffering from the FOMO version, a little well-timed aversive control in the context of large amounts of positive reinforcement might be the very thing you need. But with dogs suffering from the more clinical version of separation anxiety it might not be helpful at all and could even deepen the anxiety.

*The thing to know here is that aversive control doesn’t have to be painful or terrifying. It just needs to be sufficiently annoying to your dog that she prefers not to have it happen again.*

Unfortunately, the distinction is often less than clear. As we saw above, there can be behavioral overlaps between dogs without true separation anxiety and dogs with it. Which means we might have to do a bit of experimentation. Fortunately, this won’t take long. Why? Because if you attempt to properly use small degrees of aversive control and fail to get a quick response, then more of it probably won’t work and you should stop right away. I’ll circle back to this later.

Right now, let’s look at some of the approaches that often work when separation issues are driven more by the fear of missing out and frustration of not getting what the dog wants than the separation itself.

# The Standard Approach



The standard approach to dealing with separation issues involves ample exercise, killer treats, high value chewies, the toning down of emotional over-dependency, time and patience and, occasionally, a little bit of ‘aversive control.’

The standard scenario would go something like this: before leaving your dog alone, be sure to give her a hard run at the park or some other form of exercise, such as a vigorous game of fetch, some tug of war or anything else that burns up mental, emotional and physical energy. Then, once you get home, begin disconnecting from her a bit. Basically, ignore her until she settles and then move her to the area where you’d like her to chill while you go out.

The area itself should ideally be the same one in which you dog spends the night since, thanks to ‘situational learning,’ she is already used to doing that there. That should help let her know that that’s what we’re doing now. If your dog is still a pup (more on pups shortly) you can also use its playpen during the day. What I generally discourage is using places like garages and laundry rooms as the location of the confinement and separation. That’s because to your dog they feel exactly like what they are: cold, desolate dungeons away from everything familiar and comfortable, including everyone your dog loves. Go with the familiar and comfortable.

As you leave the area where your dog is to be confined, be sure to use killer treats and

chewies to help her associate your departure with amazing goodies she rarely, if ever, gets at any other time. In the treat department, anything top end that your dog demonstrably loves will do: [freeze dried liver](#) and other [organ meats](#), chunks of rotisserie chicken or something similar, and so on. In the chewy department, [bully sticks](#), [raw frozen beef bones](#), [smoked bones](#), [tendon toys](#), [hooves](#), [deer antlers](#), [Himalayan chews](#), and an assortment of similar items will do.

Then there are so-called ‘interactive’ dog toys. Often things like [Kong Toys](#) and various [puzzle games](#) are recommended. I recommend them also, to the degree they’re effective. Unfortunately, often Kongs and puzzle games have very little staying power. Dogs aren’t stupid. With Kongs, they’ll quickly empty them and after about five minutes, completely ignore them. And with puzzle toys, once your dog figures the puzzle out, same thing – it’ll take all of a minute or two of her attention and then it’s done.

One toy that isn’t prone to being so quickly ignored is a [‘Bob-a-Lot.’](#) It spits out treats as your dog wobbles the treat-filled toy around. And it holds a lot of treats. Here’s how we’d pull all this together. You’ve just returned from your walk or run at the park, game of fetch, or whatever other energy-draining fun you’ve just had, with a tired dog. As you settle back in to your home,

ignore her for a few minutes. As you tend to your own affairs, she'll likely settle down after the exhausting outing and the sense of togetherness you developed during the outing will begin to dissipate.

Then grab a handful of treats, chewies and whatever other 'interactive' items you're using and lure your dog into the area that you're going to use for the alone time. Once in the area, be sure to not get engaged in any affection or intimacy with your dog. You want to keep the emotional connection at this point as low as absolutely possible. Remember, we're trying to tone down emotional dependency and minimize the qualitative difference for your dog between your presence and your absence. Just set down the chewies and interactive items, then begin heading out the door.

Just before you leave, turn around and scatter the handful of whatever killer treats you brought into the area behind you and leave. Again, no goodbyes or any emotional displays. At all! Just leave. This is very important. If this works, your dog will turn around and start searching for those treats and, since you've scattered a bunch of them behind you, it'll take her a little while to find them. During that time, you disappear.

The idea is to minimize the emotional spike that your dog will experience on seeing you leave. If she's busy scarfing up treats on the floor away from the point of departure, she won't see you. And whatever panic meter spike she has on seeing you leave likely won't spike as high. That means there'll be less emotional agitation

to come down from, which is precisely the point. And she'll be more likely to show interest in the killer chewies you've left lying around. These, of course, are designed to keep your dog's attention on something she really likes and begin to associate your departures with really delicious things she never sees at any other time.

A couple of other things you might try as an adjunct to all this are [heartbeat puppy toys](#), [thunder shirts](#), [dog appeasing pheromones](#) and CBD treats or tinctures. These fall into the category of 'may or may not do anything, but no harm done.'

Heartbeat puppy toys are stuffed animals with a little heart beat sound generator and warming element that are designed to reproduce mom's warmth and heartbeat and soothe nervous puppies.

Thunder shirts are tight fitting t-shirts that, for some dogs increase their sense of security because they feel like they're being held.

Dog appeasing pheromones are synthetic hormones that mimic lactating mother's milk.

And CBD treats and tinctures can have a calming effect on dogs (more on all this later).

An additional item along these lines might be an unlaundered t-shirt with your scent on it. Not a hard item to come by. And it might offer at least a slightly soothing sense of your presence.

Now, when you've put all this together, there are several possible outcomes. One is, all this works, your dog settles down and you can go about your business. If this is the case, I'd suggest starting with relatively short periods of isolation and extending them a bit in staggered increments over the





coming days/weeks. By staggered increments I mean some days do shorter periods and other days longer. Mix it up (more on this later as well). And pretty soon you should be okay.

If, once you leave, your dog begins barking or scratching you have to try a few different things. This is where the contentious issue of the possible use of aversive control comes into play. When faced with this situation, you have two choices. You can practice a series of very quick comings and goings into your dog's area beneath the threshold of their anxiety (before they start barking, whining or scratching), extending the periods of time as you go. Or you can choose to employ some kind of reprimand to help your dog begin to exercise some emotional impulse control.

When I'm faced with this choice, I know it's time to make a judgment call. If the dog is boisterous and demanding, I'll be inclined to move toward a little aversive control. If the dog appears more panicked than anything else, I'm going to try the comings and goings first. And if I find those to work better, I might consider moving this dog to the modified and much more intensive protocol for addressing deep separation anxiety that we'll discuss further on. Let's play out both scenarios.

In the first scenario in which the dog is boisterous and demanding, I'll respond by trying some aversive control. After all, I've held up my end. I've provided ample exercise, made sure she's fed, played with and had the opportunity to eliminate, and provided a whole range of items with which to entertain herself.

Now it's time for her to hold up her end – exercise some emotional and physical impulse control and settle down. I'll have more to say on the importance of impulse control below. Stay tuned.

*If, once you leave, your dog begins barking or scratching you have to try a few different things.*

Now it's time to start experimenting. When the dog starts barking or scratching, I'll usually start by smacking my hand loudly on the door, if the dog is behind one. I'm careful not to say anything because I want the dog to think that's what doors do when you bark at them. If that doesn't work, I might throw the door open very quickly, step in, spritz the dog on the nose with a water bottle while saying "quiet" strongly, immediately turn around and go out. If she starts up again, I'd repeat the procedure. If the dog likes water, I'd switch to a Pet Corrector, a canister of compressed air available at most pet shops that startles and can scare some dogs just to the point of compliance.

One final set of items you can try for a barking dog are two types of barking collars. The first one simply **vibrates the collar** when the dog barks in the same way that a cell phone vibrates in your pocket. And the second, a **citronella barking collar**, sprays a little blast of citronella spray up under the dog's muzzle when she barks. Both are pain free and harmless but, in many cases, 'sufficiently annoying' to give the dog pause about



barking. Especially, when thanks to the goodies you've left lying around, there are so many other fun things to do.

If an approach using mild aversive control is going to work, generally it will happen fairly quickly. Within a few minutes. And if you add that up over the course of some days, you should see the problem diminishing relatively quickly.

If it doesn't, time to switch it up. My next move would be to forget about the aversive control and start practicing short comings and goings like this. Leave your dog with the setup I just described. Walk out, tick off one second, then walk back in. Ignore the dog. Hang out a moment or two, turn around and head out again. Tick off two or three seconds, return, hang out and leave again, this time perhaps for five or so seconds. What's important here is to try to return beneath the threshold of the dog's anxiety. In other words, before any barking, whining or scratching starts (with very sensitive dogs you may have to be more precise than this, a topic to which we'll turn when addressing much more serious versions of separation anxiety below).

Keep doing this, mixing up increments of time with an eye to adding time but without being in too much of a hurry. In other words, if you've just reached a threshold that's better than some previous ones, go back and do some departures for less time. You want to throw in what one of the experts on this topic calls 'easy wins.' They help consolidate gains and build the dog's confidence (more later).

In the beginning and perhaps even for some period of time, this routine can be incredibly tedious. However, it works. And it tends to have a snowballing effect. In other words, in general it will take longer to get from one second to five seconds of alone time without distress than it would to get from five seconds to ten seconds. And then to twenty, thirty, and so on. But there can also be ups and downs and you may have to buckle in for the ride. I'll have a lot more to say about this approach, which forms the core of the more serious separation anxiety program described below. Stay tuned.

Fortunately, for most dogs, one of these two approaches will often do the trick, especially if we're persistent and work on it every day. If they do not, then the much more demanding program that follows further on may be called for.

However, before we turn our attention there, let's examine some common questions that relate to all this and may impact how you develop your program.

### ***Should I use a crate?***

That depends. Some dogs do better alone when crated and others don't. Let's examine both cases.

In general, dogs like the comfort and security of small, confined spaces. That's why you so often find them lying under chairs and coffee tables and other tucked away little places. It feels safe. Just like the dens their relatives in the wolf and coyote worlds still use today. That's the understanding on which the whole idea of crate training is built.



However, since dogs are neither wolf nor coyote, it doesn't always work like that. Some dogs actually hate confinement and have to be slowly accustomed to it. In that case, what's often interpreted as separation anxiety is really more 'barrier frustration' and rebellion against confinement.

In relation to separation anxiety, crates are not absolutely essential. However, they're incredibly useful for a wide range of reasons (boarding, airplane travel, car rides, vet visits, etc.). Which is why it's worth spending time teaching your dog to tolerate confinement in one and even learn to like it. Let's take a quick look at how we can help a dog learn to enjoy the safety of a crate.

The best way to start is by not forcing the issue but convincing your dog that the whole idea of hanging out in a crate was hers. To facilitate this, the first thing to do is to make sure that the inside of the crate is comfortable. That means, lots of nice bedding, perhaps an unlaundered t-shirt of yours, a few killer chewies and a cover to give it a more den-like feeling (a towel will do). Unless, of course, you have a dog with a heavy coat, like a Husky or Bernese Mountain Dog. They prefer cool, hard surfaces to soft, cushy ones. So, your first job is to figure out what your dog likes. And then provide it.

Once you've done that, there are a few tricks to expedite the process. Here's one. Throughout the day, perhaps ten or more times, toss a small handful of treats into your dog's crate so that the dog can see you do it. Say 'go to bed' while you're doing it. Of

course, she'll dash into the crate to retrieve the treats, which lie hidden in the folds of the bedding. Most owners would then follow up by closing the door once the dog is inside. Don't do that!

*In relation to separation anxiety, crates are not absolutely essential. However, they're incredibly useful for a wide range of reasons*

Instead, simply let your dog back out. The first thing you want to do is to assure your dog that you're not going to lock her in every time she goes in. In fact, we'll hardly do it at all. Pretty soon your dog will figure out that when you say 'go to bed,' if she runs in the crate, she'll find a bunch of treats hidden between the folds of the bedding. And she can come right back out. Do this throughout the day at random intervals. How often? More is better. Ten to twenty times a day would be great.

Once your dog gets the game, you can add another wrinkle. When she's not looking, scatter a handful of treats into her crate just as above. Later, when she's nearby, you can suggest, 'go to bed,' without throwing the treats in. Out of habit, she's likely to look. And, lo and behold, there they are. Pretty soon she'll start snooping around in there hoping to find something. Do not disappoint! Leave things in there for her to find. Soon she'll be looking around in there with no cue whatsoever from you. Excellent!

Then you can add another wrinkle. Find something like a smoked bone or bully stick and tie it into the back of the crate so that your dog can't take it out. Leave it in there for her to find and, since she can't take it out, she'll have to settle in the crate with the item. Again, do not close the door.

You can supplement all this by feeding your dog her meals in the crate and even reaching in and giving her belly rubs when she's in there and so on. Any positive experience your dog can have in the crate without fear of being locked in is the right direction. Just don't close the door. Yet.

Also, make the crate the most comfortable place around. For dogs who like soft, comfy resting areas, put the crate on an area such as a tile or hardwood floor that's hard and uncomfortable for your dog. Then put your dog's favorite bed and blankets in there. If you can, make other areas inaccessible (more later). Do all the things suggested above and there's

a good chance that your dog will begin to choose the crate on her own.

For dogs who like cold floors, put the crate on a rug, if you can, and leave it bare inside. You get the idea.

'All well and good,' you say. But what about closing the door on the crate?

You can add this in once your dog has lost all reluctance to go into the crate and hang out there. In small increments. If your dog has settled down in the crate, walk over, close the door, leave it closed for a second and open it. If your dog wants to come out, let her. Then try again a little later. But if she's settled a bit keep up with this routine: close the door, walk a little bit away, return and open. Do it again, but this time a little bit longer. If you see your dog getting uneasy and starting to want to get out, reduce the level of time with the door closed and keep repeating.

You can also supplement this

***Because there are so many areas in your dog's life where crates are beneficial (airline travel, boarding, car rides, vet visits, the list goes on...) crate training is definitely worth the time you put into it.***

by practicing down-stays with your dog in the crate, both with the door open and then closed (if she doesn't know it, teach her). With your dog in the crate with the door open, ask her to 'down-stay'. Once she's down, practice the stay by moving away from the crate around the room and returning with a treat to reward her now and again, just as you would if you were training her for the stay anywhere else. Slowly add time and distance and always open the door before your dog gets anxious about it.

If you put all this together with some time and patience, most dogs will begin to adapt to their crate, some more quickly than others. And because there are so many areas in your dog's life where crates are beneficial (airline travel, boarding, car rides, vet visits, the list goes on...) crate training is definitely worth the time you put into it.

***What about giving my dog the whole house when leaving?***

While crate training is extraordinarily helpful in managing your dog for a variety of reasons, it's not absolutely essential when it comes to





addressing separation anxiety. Some dogs do a lot better with more room available to them because they're not struggling against 'barrier frustration.'

In that case, simply practice the things mentioned in the standard approach to addressing separation anxiety above, but in the much more open space. This could be your whole house or a section of it that you've cordoned off with some baby gates or in some other fashion.

When doing this, I'll often add one more wrinkle to the standard protocol by hiding little handfuls of treats in various areas around the room, such as behind planters, in corners, etc., for the dog to find later. In other words, in addition to tossing a bunch of treats out behind me and setting down some killer chewies just as I leave, I'll hide five or six or seven little piles of treats around the room for the dog to find later as she's bored and rooting around.

The hope is that by the time your dog is done grabbing the treats you've tossed behind yourself on the way out, rooting around for the hidden ones and then settling down with the chewy items you've also left behind, that your dog will have acclimated to the fact that you're gone and finally settle down.

### ***Possible Outcomes***

If you've done all of this there are a handful of possible outcomes. The first is that it all works and you're one your way to overcoming your separation issues. The second is that your dog will find and finish all the goodies

and then return to behaviors expressing separation anxiety. The third is that your dog is so anxious about all of this that she won't even touch the treats and goodies you leave behind.

***If you've done all of this there are a handful of possible outcomes.***

Regarding the second point, if your dog finishes all the goodies and then returns to a state of anxiety, you'll probably need to work on the much more in-depth treatment protocol described in the second half of this booklet.

And regarding the third, your dog not being interested in any of these items without you around, there's one more step to try before moving to this program. Try not feeding your dog at all except during periods of alone time. And keep these relatively short. The idea, of course, is that hunger may help her overcome her anorexia and if it does, it can slowly let the dog know that the alone periods produce nourishment and comfort and that this can slowly translate into greater ease with being left alone.

If none of these approaches help you resolve the separation issues, then you'll probably need to turn to the more in-depth program described a little further on.

# A Few Other Points

Before diving into the nuts and bolts of the heavy-duty separation anxiety protocol, let's examine a few other ancillary issues.

## ***On Impulse Control and Barking it Out***

A common piece of advice often dished out in response to a dog barking when left alone is to let them bark it out. This is almost always terrible advice. At most, I let whining and barking go on for a minute or two and only if it appears to be dissipating during that time until disappearing into silence. If the behavior diminishes

over a relatively short period, then doing nothing is probably the right move.

But if it goes on or escalates, it's time to intervene. And sooner rather than later. If the barking appears to be of the 'demand barking' variety I will use the approach described above. If it appears to be driven significant issues of anxiety rather than simple FOMO, then I will put the approach that will follow in a few pages into practice.

However, before moving on there's another important issue to consider: impulse control in general and emotional impulse control in particular. When teaching my classes, I often tell my students that if you had to net dog training down to a single core principle, it would be teaching them to exercise impulse control and check in with you. This is something that has to be learned, as for most dogs there's almost no cognitive activity between an impulse and an action. When they see your \$400 Italian leather shoes sitting there and are tempted to chew them up, they don't think about it. They feel the impulse and do something about it. There are all kinds of training exercises that address this issue. But the point is that it's something that has to be learned.

The same is true for emotional impulse control. Just because you want something doesn't mean a temper tantrum will help you get it. The issue is that allowing a dog who is having some kind of FOMO

temper tantrum to continue barking generally means that this will lead to an upward spiral in which your dog gets increasingly worked up because the emotion is self-reinforcing. This can then rise to the level of real distress where the dog continues to whip up its own anxiety in an endless loop.

We've all had that experience. We get worked into an emotional state in an argument and keep whipping it up more and more until someone has to tell us to step back, take a breath and cool down.

That's precisely what some of the 'aversive control' methods mentioned above are designed to achieve – compel the dog to take a step back and cool down instead of continually spinning the wheel of their complaints. I've had many experiences with overwrought dogs whipping themselves into an emotional frenzy during which they'll touch none of the yummy items I've left for them, not because of anxiety, which can cause anorexia, but because of the frustrated emotional storm they're now caught in.

In many cases, when I've put, say a citronella barking collar, on the dog, after a few corrections the startled dog settles down. And within a few moments starts showing interest in the various chew toys and treats we've left lying around. That means that the slight correction is compelling the dog to exercise impulse control and, as with any other exercise, this is something that has to be learned and practiced. If your dog falls into this category you'll know for sure



that the distress around separation was an expression of FOMO, not true anxiety.

There are many ways to help a dog learn to exercise impulse control. Almost all well-taught obedience will convey this. Asking your dog for a simple sit-stay when she really just wants to run out the door is one way. Another is asking for the same sit-stay prior to meals. And another is putting her on what's called a learn to earn program. This simply means teaching her to do something for you before you do anything for her. It's a way of teaching dogs to say 'please.'

For instance, if she wants to play with you and you're so inclined, just ask for a sit or down or anything before you play. It's a little dose of simple manners to help her understand the structure of social relationships in your house and to help her develop the muscles of impulse control. The underlying message is, 'you don't make demands on me. I make them on you. And when you comply, good things happen.' Regardless of whatever other issues you may have with your dog, this is the best foundation for a solid, long-term relationship.

### ***Toning Down the Overly Emotional Nature of your Dog's Relationship with You***

When dealing with separation anxiety, whether it's the FOMO kind, true anxiety or a little bit of both, one of the things you want to try and do is to decrease the felt emotional gap for your dog between when you're there and when you're not.

While it's true that some dogs who don't have issues with separation anxiety will 'shadow' their owners simply because they enjoy being with them, dogs with separation anxiety do so because they can't bear the emotional state of being further apart. Without being near you they don't feel whole. And that's terrible.

### ***If your dog needs to be velcroed to you in order to feel whole, you can help diminish her co-dependence in a few ways.***

If your dog needs to be velcroed to you in order to feel whole, you can help diminish her co-dependence in a few ways. All of them fall into the category of toning down the overly emotional connection that you and she both participate in. You can help her tolerate a little more emotional distance and slowly grow comfortable with it in a few different ways.

They include reducing or eliminating the kind of constant doting on her that some people engage in. Of course, this doting is a natural and rewarding part of dog ownership, especially for people with emotional voids in their lives for other reasons. That's not meant in a negative way at all. One of the biggest benefits of dog ownership is the simple, uncomplicated and deep emotional connection they provide. However, in cases of emotional dependency that very positive feature can become toxic. Dependency is terrible,

both for your dog and for you. Much deeper relationships are forged from a strong sense of independence on both sides. And in cases of separation anxiety, that has to be developed.

This can be helped by avoiding constantly doting on your dog. Resist the temptation to endlessly coo and cuddle her through any and every circumstance. The same is true for indulging in wild homecomings. Instead of having a five-minute celebration with your dog when you return, you'd both be much better served by simply ignoring her for a few minutes after you come home and waiting for her to settle down a bit before you begin engaging. And even then, you'd do it calmly. A kind stroke behind the ears, a little belly rub or a soft hug. Not a wild party. That way you're not whipping up her dog's emotional intensity, which simply increases for her the felt difference between your presence and your absence, precisely what we want to diminish.

Similarly, before leaving, avoid long, heartfelt goodbyes. All those do is get your dog more emotionally connected with you just before leaving. Not unlike a lover leaving the bed right in the middle of the action for no apparent reason. When you're preparing to leave, begin ignoring your dog five or ten minutes before you do. Then toss down whatever combination of items from the above protocols work for you and simply walk out the door without further ado.

You can also help diminish emotional over-dependence in your dog when home. While



in the house, start practicing long stays with you further and further away from your dog for increasing periods of time. You can also insert short absences by ditching around a corner for a few seconds while your dog is holding her stay. As your dog gets used to this you can extend the periods of time you're out of sight. And once you've done that you can stagger these brief absences in unpredictable increments – 10 seconds, 30 seconds, 5 seconds, 45 seconds, and so on. Mix it up, throw in some easy wins and slowly extend duration.

This isn't the place to go into how to teach that, but there are any number of ways to learn, including from the [level 1 training videos](#) freely available on my website, my book [Integrated Dog Training](#), other resources on the Internet or your local dog training club. Carrying out an explicit instruction like a stay can help keep your dog focused on her task rather than just having her mind drifting neurotically, obsessing about your absence. All this will help increase your dog's impulse control and tolerance of distance between you.

As an adjunct to this, you can also set up 'tethering stations' around your house to which you can anchor your dog while you're doing other things. For instance, if your dog is on the sofa with you every night, you could start by putting her in a doggie bed a few feet away, tethering her with a leash to a piece of furniture, giving her a few killer chewies and having her learn to hang out there. She can still see you. After all, you're just a few feet away. But she's going to have to learn to tolerate

just a bit of physical distance. Once she's accustomed to his, you can then anchor her further away and then further away again.

*One of the biggest benefits of dog ownership is the simple, uncomplicated and deep emotional connection they provide.*

Then you can practice some comings and goings (these will form a major part of the program that follows). In the sofa example above, you might take a moment to run to the kitchen to grab a drink or to quickly use the bathroom. For those few moments, your dog will have to tolerate being on her own. But you'll be back before she gets a chance to get worked up about it. And each such increment helps develop tolerance of your absence as well as impulse control. These increments can then be slowly extended until your dog becomes increasingly indifferent to your brief comings and goings.

### ***On Sleeping in Bed with you***

What about sleeping in bed with you? Opinions on this are divided. A few small studies failed to show a link between dogs sleeping in bed with their owners and significant separation anxiety. That leads some trainers to claim that there's no connection between them at all. Yet, while it may be true that sleeping with your dog might not cause severe separation anxiety, common sense and my own experience tell me that it



certainly doesn't help. Especially if you're in the category of someone who has an overly co-dependent relationship with your dog.

*If you really like having your dog in bed with you, you can work a compromise in which you have her in bed while you're settling in for the night, then, when it's finally 'light's out,' gently move her to the side.*

My strong recommendation is that if you've got such issues, you should engage in a process that some have called 'gentle disengagement.' It's essentially the same process described above involving tethering your dog at some distance from you where she can see you but not be right on you. In this case, you'd simply have your dog begin sleeping in a dog bed or crate next to your bed. If she won't stay in her bed, you can temporarily use a tether just as described above. Usually, after a week or so, you won't need the tether anymore as your dog will simply acclimate to the new situation.

If you really like having your dog in bed with you, you can work a compromise in which you have her in bed while you're settling in for the night, then, when it's finally 'light's out,' gently move her to the side. Then, in the morning, when it's 'lights on,' you can bring her up again and hang out a bit to start your day. That way you both still get the snuggles and the TLC but you're also creating a little sense of emotional space.

## ***The Importance of Exercise***

'Tired dogs are good dogs' is one of the oldest adages in the training world. For good reason. It's largely true. First, exercise releases all manner of feel-good chemicals in your dog's brain that can help protect her against emotional swings.

Also, dogs who've had a good romp at the park with other dogs or with you on a hike or in a game of fetch are going to tend to come home and want to relax. There'll tend to be less FOMO for that dog when you leave, especially if you outfit your place in the ways described above. And it'll make the above methods much more likely to succeed. Tired dogs tend to sleep. Untired ones have all that energy with which to feed their FOMO. So, to a point, it helps.

However, it's possible to overdo it. How do I know? Because I made that mistake early on in my training career with one of my own dogs, a Standard Poodle named Zoe. By overdoing it on the exercise, I managed to turn her into a super athlete who almost no amount of running, jumping and playing could fully tire out. Rookie mistake. Don't make it.

One of my mentors at the time explained to me that all dogs should get a reasonable amount of exercise. But beyond that, they have to learn to regulate themselves, which takes us back to the issue of impulse control mentioned above. She was right.

## ***Playing Background Music During your Absences***

A common piece of advice regarding separation issues is to play some soothing classical music



to help your dog relax. While evidence supporting this strategy is mixed, it falls into the category of no harm done. In most cases. In cases of extreme anxiety, however, it can serve as another trigger for the anxiety if your dog begins to associate the music with your leaving.

To avoid this, be sure to play the same music at other times when you're not leaving and your dog feels secure. And begin playing it twenty or so minutes prior to your departure. Otherwise, you risk the music becoming a 'pre-departure cue' and trigger.

### ***Shelter Dogs and Separation Anxiety***

Some authors claim that there's little link between dogs coming out of shelter or rescue situations into a new home and separation anxiety. This does not line up with my experience. Over the course of some 40,000 private consultations I performed over three decades of private training, I found that the overwhelming majority of dogs coming out of shelters experience some degree of distress when left alone by their new owners. This should come as little surprise. Rescue dogs, whatever their backgrounds, have been through a lot. Some more than others. That's for sure. But all lost a home or never had one to start with. So, it makes sense that now that they've found their forever home (of course, they don't know it's a forever home yet), they're going to be damned if they lose it. And that means they're going to keep a real close eye on you.

What this means is that if you adopt a rescue dog, you should

at least be prepared for some struggles with separation and work from the very beginning to teach your dog to tolerate alone time. Bake structured, daily alone time into your new dog's routine in small increments using some of the methods described above. Or, if those don't seem to do the trick, refer to the intensive program in the last section of this book.

### ***Separation Anxiety in Puppies***

Many puppies when first arriving at their new homes display signs of distress when being left alone in a crate or a pen. This shouldn't come as a surprise. Right up until the day that you picked them up from the breeder, they were snuggling with mom and littermates in a furry pile. Then you come along, snatch them up, stick them in a box and expect them to remain mum about the whole thing. Might happen. Probably not.

In all likelihood, you're going to get some crying and whining and general fussing about the whole thing. My recommendation is to start with your pup in a crate next to your bed so she can see you and know there's someone nearby. All the rules of crate training mentioned above can help her to begin to acclimate to this new situation. I do not recommend crating your pup in some out of the way place in your house like the garage or laundry room. This is likely to just freak them out. If you don't want your dog sleeping in your bedroom long term, the best way to begin is still actually by starting there.

With your pup's crate next to your bed, covered with a towel

with enough of the front of the crate uncovered so that your pup can see you in the bed, she will tend to develop a sense of safety pretty quickly. If she starts barking or scratching like mad and it goes on for more than thirty seconds or so, I'd recommend responding. Letting them cry it out, just like letting them bark it out, is generally bad advice. If your pup receives no response to her cries for help or attention, it could result in heightened anxiety developing quickly.

There are different ways to respond. In the beginning, if your pup is next to your bed and you've taken all the necessary measures to make sure she's comfortable (nice bed, small assortment of chewies, heartbeat puppy toy, a pup that's gone potty, had plenty of exercise and so on), then it's time to respond. I'll usually start with a squirt of water or light smack on top of the crate to startle the pup and interrupt the behavior. That often does the trick. Not very different from what's described above with the use of some mild 'aversive control.' If it doesn't, then your pup may need the more intensive program described below. Or you can start the whole process by having your pup in the crate on the bed with you to provide an even greater sense of closeness.

Once your pup acclimates to all this, you can begin moving the crate a little further away from the bed each night or two. Small increments of a few inches or so are ideal. It won't take much time for your pup to be comfortable in her crate near your bedroom door, then just outside of it, then just outside and down the hall and so on.

From there, all the rules of alone outlined above will apply and you can take it from there. That means using the protocols outlined above to help with separation during the day. Concerning this, I highly recommend building structured alone time into your pup's day every day. This can be broken up into three stages.

In the early stages, up until perhaps five months or so, I suggest crating or confining your pup twice a day for around an hour and half. At least that's the target. Depending on your situation, you may have to start with periods much shorter than that and use the protocols outlined in the section that follows. It's best to choose those periods of the day during which your pup is most likely to want to go down for a nap anyway. That's usually going to be after having eaten, eliminated and played for a while. Mid-morning and mid-afternoon are ideal.

In the middle stages from five or so months to eight or ten months, I suggest combining these into two to three hour periods of alone time somewhere during the middle of the day at a time that makes the most sense for you. Remember, we're trying to acclimate your pup to the ordinary rhythms of your day as much as possible.

In the later stages, when your pup is approaching a year or so, the goal would be to be able to leave her home alone eight to twelve hours, if necessary.

This would, of course, not be something you'd do on a regular basis. But, as well all know, life is unpredictable and unforeseen circumstances can force us to be away from home longer than we intended. And those circumstances are usually emergencies. So, we want to have a dog that can have some tolerance for emergency situations, which means that during your emergency the one thing you won't have to worry about is your dog having a meltdown at home.

The foregoing covers the range of possible responses to separation issues of various kinds, particularly those more driven by frustration and the fear of missing out than the much deeper and more difficult variety grounded in true anxiety. One clue that your dog's issues might be driven by the latter is that if you've tried some combination of the above strategies with some diligence to little or no effect. In that case, you'll have to turn your efforts in a more intensive direction. Let's do that now.



# Separation Anxiety Intensive Protocol

The nuts and bolts of this program are simple. But its demands are high. The basic training involves daily routines of structured comings and goings that have to take place beneath the threshold of your dog's anxiety. In other words, before she begins expressing any signs of distress. The hard part is that during this process your dog should experience absolutely no episodes of alone time that will trigger anxiety. In other words, she can't be left alone. At all. That's really hard. More on this shortly.

The idea is to slowly get your dog used to absences in such a way that they do not trigger anxiety and start the whole panic

loop over again. Your dog needs to experience absences, lots of them, without triggering the anxiety. Remember, anxiety is a much different and more difficult thing to address than frustration and fear of missing out. It's like a panic attack in humans and isn't really subject to things like impulse control. The only way to reliably resolve this kind of fear is by slowly convincing your dog through her own experience that there's nothing to fear. That she's safe. Deeply. And that takes time. A lot of it. And the patience to bear with it.

Generally, the program looks like this. We begin with having to evaluate several things. The first is

whether the anxiety is the FOMO kind or true anxiety. And in the case of true anxiety, we have to figure out at what point in the departure process your dog begins to experience signs of distress. This will give us the baseline from which to build our program.

Both of these will require the use of some video equipment, careful observation and equally careful note taking. It would look something like this. We'd set up our equipment in such a way that we can see what your dog is doing anywhere in the area where she's alone. Then we'd look for the subtle signs of oncoming distress and note exactly how long after your departure the signs of distress begin appearing. These will form the baseline for our program.

For instance, if we notice that she begins becoming agitated within fifteen seconds of your departure, then we'll know that for our beginning training protocols we'd have to come back before that threshold is hit, perhaps after five seconds. So, that's where we'd start our daily routines – doing comings and goings with durations in the five to fifteen seconds range and then slowly building from there (stay tuned for more on this).

We'd also have to re-evaluate the use of some of the items mentioned above, such as leaving bones and chewies and interactive toys or even leaving music on for your dog. That's because while on the one hand they can act help calm dogs who are expressing





the FOMO version of separation distress, they can actually become triggers signaling oncoming distress for a dog with deep anxiety around this. In other words, the moment they see the killer bone coming out, they know you're leaving and instead of calming them down, it triggers the anxiety even earlier than it would have been triggered had you just left. The same goes for things like soft music and similar gimmicks.

Regarding high value chewies, in most cases when the separation issues are driven by the fear of missing out, I recommend only bringing the chewies out on the special occasion of your departures. That way your dog would come to understand that the best things come out in your absence (see above). Not feeding them breakfast in the morning can help accelerate all this. The same strategy can be very helpful when first introducing confinement in things like crates and ex-pens (folding, collapsible metal playpens) and when teaching your dog to accept some distance from you as in the tether tactic described above.

With true anxiety, however, we have to flip the script. For two reasons. First, and perhaps most importantly, you don't want to risk your dog associating the items only with your departures. To avoid this, she should have them available at many other very pleasurable and relaxing times as well. That way they don't become an unintentional, adverse 'pre-departure cue' (more on these in a moment).

Second, in the event that your dog isn't anorexic and will show interest in the bone we run the

risk of getting a false read on her actual tolerance for alone time. Some dogs will chew on the item for a while, but the moment it's gone the other signs of anxiety surface. In that case, we don't really have an accurate idea of exactly how much true alone time your dog can tolerate. And that's absolutely key for this program to work.

*Regarding high value chewies, in most cases when the separation issues are driven by the fear of missing out, I recommend only bringing the chewies out on the special occasion of your departures.*

That said, one could argue that if your dog was willing to chew on the bone in the first place, then her separation anxiety couldn't be that bad because truly stressed out dogs won't eat. That might be true. But it's hard to say. Some dogs could have a degree of anxiety and still work on the chewie in the same way that some people eat as a compensation for depression. The telltale sign will be if your dog starts showing symptoms of distress the moment the goodies are gone.

To make all this more confusing, there might be times when having a chewie with your dog who showed no interest in it initially could be helpful. That's because if, over time, your dog does begin to show interest in the chewie, it could indicate that the anorexia associated with the



anxiety is diminishing, which, in turn, suggests that the anxiety is as well. Of course, it could still mask negative feelings but it would tell us that they're diminishing and may even help speed the process.

All this highlights the complexities involved both in making a proper assessment in the beginning, developing the appropriate protocols and sometimes experimenting around until we hit the right combination of factors for your dog.

### ***Pre-Departure Cues***

A related issue is that of so-called 'pre-departure cues.' I did not mention this in the protocols in the previous section because I wanted to address them here.

Pre-departure cues are all those little things you do to prepare to leave the house: change your clothes, pack your purse or briefcase, turn off your computer, pick up your keys, put on your coat or hat or jacket, open the door, walk out, start the car and so on.

The traditional advice is to separate these cues from your actual departures and 'systematically desensitize' your dog to each of them in small, isolated increments so that they do not trigger your dog's anxiety in anticipation of your departure because your dog can't tell whether you're leaving or not. However, the thinking around this has changed of late. And for good reason. At some point, those pre-departure cues will, in fact, lead to an absence. So, there's a bit of a trick being played on the dog that doesn't actually impact her felt quality of alone time. It just makes it more surprising when you leave.

To remedy this, we need to invert this advice. We'll need to incorporate 'pre-departure cues' into our training protocols so that they signal to your dog an impending, non-stressful absence from you. And for that to work, you'll need to establish some baseline tolerance for alone time, say thirty seconds, before integrating pre-departure cues into your routine. You'll also need to bear in mind an important principle – lowering your criteria in one area while raising it in other. Which means that if you're going to begin introducing some pre-departure cues, you'll probably want to decrease the amount of time you're absent. At least until your dog can get fully acclimated to the new routine. Then you can re-raise the criteria you lowered (stay tuned for more in the sample training plan below).

### ***No Stressful Absences of Any Kind***

This is the hard part. And it's really hard. During the process of relieving your dog's anxiety, it's critical that she experiences absolutely no stressful absences of any kind. Not kidding. None. Not one. This is key to the long-term resolution of her distress. And while it may make you feel imprisoned in the short term, it will free you both in the long run.

The reason for this rigidity is that part of what will slowly help your dog get over all of this is allowing the knee jerk departure/anxiety panic cycle to cease being activated so that, through disuse, it will slowly fade in memory until all power is drained from it. In the beginning that's done by never



leaving her alone. But that time is used to develop tolerance for brief periods of alone time, which can then be slowly extended until finally you can leave her for increasingly longer periods.

The good news is that once you begin your training program, which can feel very slow and incremental initially, there will tend to be an accelerating rate of return as your dog's stress levels decrease and her tolerance for brief absences beneath her anxiety thresholds increases. While perhaps tiny in the beginning, they'll compound in time, not unlike interest. But only patient investors see the big returns. So, be patient.

And creative. Use your friends, dog walkers, day care centers, pet sitters, neighborhood kids and so on to help out. Take your dog with you when you can. Meet your friends for lunch or dinner at venues that allow dogs in their outdoor areas. Perhaps post on NextDoor to see if any neighbors would be willing to have your dog over for company or leave their dog with you on occasion. Sometimes groomers with whom your dog is comfortable are willing to help out since they see your dog regularly anyway. And so on. This is an area where our training team at [Alpha Dog](#) can help a lot as well. Please reach out and we'll help you build a plan.

At this point you might be asking yourself, 'there's got to be a way around this.' There isn't. Unfortunately. That's why for many trainers who specialize in this area, a refusal or inability to comply with this demand is a deal killer. That's because they understand that by not holding to this

standard, they're likely setting both themselves and their client up for failure. And, of course, they'll get the blame.

Some trainers of bolder constitution may offer a couple of tricks to help alleviate the damage done to the program by leaving your dog to the throes of another anxiety attack.

*One is to try to trick your dog into believing you're still there when you're not by leaving on a recording of your common house noises when you depart.*

One is to try to trick your dog into believing you're still there when you're not by leaving on a recording of your common house noises when you depart. You'd simply record the sounds of your house during ordinary periods of busyness and play it back when you're gone. The trick is leaving without your dog noticing that you've turned the sounds on, which could quickly cause your recordings to become yet another trigger for your dog's anxiety alongside other 'pre-departure' cues. To overcome this, you should play the recording from an area where your dog can't see you doing it and won't be when you leave. You should also start the playback a little while before you actually leave so that the recorded sounds blend with the actual sounds of you still being there for a while. And then you should slip out quietly.

The other trick involves setting up a 'safety stimulus.' This involves wearing some special item, say a

hat or particular pair of glasses, during those periods when you're working on your daily departure assignments that indicate to your dog that this is one of those safe departure routines that she's slowly coming to tolerate. Then, when you actually have to leave, you don't wear that particular item and you use a different part of the house for the separation so that you protect your dog's association of safety with your regular place of practice.

While these strategies may be marginally helpful, they are far from ideal and at best protect some of the gains you've made. At worst, they won't help at all and you'll be setting back both your and your dog, potentially significantly.

One additional stopgap measure you can use in the event that you have to unavoidably leave your dog despite your best efforts is medication. And I'd highly recommend it. I'll have a lot more to say about that in a moment. But for now, in situations like this, I'd suggest using something like Trazadone to heavily sedate your dog during the stressful period, much as you might for a dog experiencing terror during fireworks displays or heavy thunderstorms, like mine does. That way at least she won't have a conscious experience of your departure and will consequently experience no stress in relation to your absence. This will help keep your program and progress intact.

### ***You can't Reinforce Emotions, only Behaviors***

One of the key things in making the program that follows work is always returning to your dog

beneath the threshold of her anxiety. In other words, before she starts experiencing distress. Careful observation and record keeping (more below) will help assure this. But mistakes happen even with the best laid plans.

There will likely be times when,

***If you're this far into the program and have determined that the intensive version of the separation anxiety protocols is called for, then any form of aversive control, no matter how mild, should be avoided at all costs.***

for one reason or another, you've stayed away a bit too long, your dog crosses her anxiety threshold and begins barking. What should you do? If you're this far into the program and have determined that the intensive version of the separation anxiety protocols is called for, then any form of aversive control, no matter how mild, should be avoided at all costs. But doesn't that leave you in a bit of a pickle? If you return when she's barking without any form of reprimand, aren't you just reinforcing the barking and making

everything worse?

Not necessarily. In this case, the barking is related to an emotion – fear. And your dog is trying to call you back to relieve that fear. It's fear and the desire for relief that's driving the behavior, not a temper tantrum to get what they want. And you can't reinforce feelings. Only behaviors. So, is returning when your dog is barking ideal? No. Far from it. But again, mistakes happen and we have to roll with the punches. In this case, we have to understand that we've left longer than we should have and adjust our expectations and the duration of our training exercises accordingly.

This principle cuts both ways. Many trainers suggest rewarding your dog with treats after some successful period of alone time because, in their minds, they're rewarding the dog for being calm. But again, you can't reinforce feelings. And in this case, you'd risk winding your dog up again with excitement over your presence and the treats it promises rather than keeping her in the calm state you want her to associate with being left alone. So, don't do that.





## ***Medication – First or Last Resort?***

The question of anti-anxiety medication is often a charged one and many people resist it when first mentioned. The reasons are various. But they often include a degree of ‘transference’ in which the owner ‘transfers’ whatever ideas they have about managing anxiety with medication in humans onto their dogs. It can also include notions of having failed their dog by not successfully training this out of them without medication and fears of being judged by others. My advice is, do yourself a favor and stop doing that also.

The thing is, dogs don’t have to ‘work out’ their issues. They don’t have to ‘take responsibility’ for them. Helping them work those out is our job. And medication, by lowering your dog’s general level of anxiety, can rapidly make her more trainable and amenable to behavior modification.

Another common objection, which is often a mere cover for one of the above deeper sources of resistance, is the notion that meds will just knock the dog out, change their personalities and turn them into zombies. They won’t. In some instances, a little drowsiness or lethargy can occur in the very beginning of treatment, as your dog’s system acclimates to the meds. But this will tend to dissipate quickly and produce an easier-going dog more amenable to training. If there are significant personality changes, which is rare, then you should consult with your veterinarian and select a different med.

That said, I want to be perfectly clear. Meds by themselves won’t

help. Not much, anyway. But meds used as an adjunct to rigorous behavior modification protocols will. A lot. Be sure to mention your understanding of this point to your vet when asking about meds. They’re listening for it and will generally resist prescribing meds to folks who just want to throw a pill at the problem.

***The point is, I encourage you to drop whatever hesitation you might have concerning the use of anti-anxiety meds in your behavior modification protocol and embrace the motto, ‘better living through chemistry.’***

The point is, I encourage you to drop whatever hesitation you might have concerning the use of anti-anxiety meds in your behavior modification protocol and embrace the motto, ‘better living through chemistry.’

In other words, considering medication as an adjunct to this program should be a first resort not the last one. That’s because any dog in need of the difficult protocol that follows is, by definition, already wracked with debilitating levels of anxiety. And anything we can do to lower those will both help your dog feel better and accelerate the process of getting through all this.

Let’s take a quick look at what’s available. This can be broadly divided into two categories: those used on a regular, long-term basis or maintenance medications and



those used on a spot basis, or situational medications.

Maintenance medications are given on a daily basis and generally help adjust serotonin levels (the feel-good chemical in your brain), which, in turn, elevates mood. The most common one in use today is fluoxetine, which goes by various brand names including Prozac and Reconcile. Both are SSRIs (selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors) and inhibit the brain's metabolism of serotonin, which results in higher levels of it in the brain, where it can have its feel-good effects.

Another commonly prescribed medication for dogs with anxiety is Clomipramine, a tricyclic anti-depressant that blocks the reuptake of norepinephrine as well as serotonin. Amitriptyline (Elavil) falls into this category as well. Because of their broader effect profile and possible associated side effects, many vets prefer to begin with some version of fluoxetine. Obviously, this is something you should discuss with your vet.

The main thing to understand in both cases is that neither of these meds are habit forming nor are they sedatives nor do they have nasty side-effects. They've been heavily researched and in use with both humans and dogs for decades. They won't change your dog's personality nor will they be likely to be needed for the long term. At most, in the initial phases your dog might experience a bit of lethargy and loss of appetite. But these are passing phases.

Situational or 'episodic' medications include

benzodiazepines, which are minor tranquilizers. These can be used on a spot basis as needed and include diazepam (Valium) and alprazolam (Xanax). In this context, you might consider 'dosing' your dog twenty to thirty minutes prior to the kind of training sessions outlined below.

***They won't change your dog's personality nor will they be likely to be needed for the long term. At most, in the initial phases your dog might experience a bit of lethargy and loss of appetite. But these are passing phases.***

But be aware that in some dogs, due to some quirk in brain chemistry, benzodiazepines can have the opposite of the desired effect and make your dog more agitated than she was before. In that case, try something else.

Trazodone is a useful alternative. It can be used both as a maintenance med or on a spot basis. It prevents the reuptake of serotonin, norepinephrine, and dopamine. But it also has the sedating properties of benzodiazepines. It works wonders for my own dog and his terror in the face of fireworks and thunderstorms. And it helps my wife's dog tolerate the dreaded airplane trips she takes him on.

There are other, lesser known medications available as well, such as Clonidine. But their



effectiveness is mixed. So, I'd suggest sticking with the staples mentioned above. Again, consult with your vet and make a decision together, knowing that you may need to make some adjustments as you observe the med's impact on your dog and the effectiveness of your program.

Two other items deserve mention here. The use of CBDs and of 'alternative' remedies often billed as 'holistic.'

CBD stands for 'cannabidiol' and is an extract of the marijuana plant. It's non-psychoactive and has been touted as a broad-spectrum remedy for a range of things. Anxiety is one of them. Some trainers argue against the use of CBDs due to the almost total lack of regulation of this industry and insufficient research on its use in dogs. I'm not one of them. My experience tells me that CBDs fall into the category of 'may do something; no harm done.'

As far as other 'holistic' remedies are concerned, to date, my experience leaves me unimpressed. Many years ago, when I was in my first or second year of professional training, I raised the issue of alternatives with one of my mentors who was extremely knowledgeable. Her advice to me at the time was to give it all a try but that I'd likely find that both well-established training routines and well-established meds would be what would get the best results most efficiently. She was right.

That said, and in the interests of even-handedness, I'll go ahead and supply links to few

alternative remedies I've seen other trainers recommend. Again, they fall into the category of 'no harm done so why not try' and include [Anxitane](#), [Composure](#) and [Rescue Remedy](#). You'll have to do your own research on these and consult with your vet, especially if you're using other meds as well.

***One final thing in relation to neurochemistry, which is small but noteworthy, is that some dog foods contain a lot of corn and studies have shown that corn can have a negative impact on serotonin levels. So, for this reason and any number of others, I'd suggest ditching foods with lots of corn if your dog has issues with any kind of anxiety, including separation anxiety.***

One final thing in relation to neurochemistry, which is small but noteworthy, is that some dog foods contain a lot of corn and studies have shown that corn can have a negative impact on serotonin levels. So, for this reason and any number of others, I'd suggest ditching foods with lots of corn if your dog has issues with any kind of anxiety, including separation anxiety.

***That brings us to the end of the overview and the entry point to our program.***

# Getting Started

The first thing to bear in mind is the need for patience. The program that follows is demanding, not because of the thirty or so minutes a day that will be required for its practice, but because of the fact that you're not going to be able to leave your dog alone at all during this program. And because it's all going to take a while. What's a while? Think in terms of months, not weeks. And think flexibly. It could be longer. Of course, it might be shorter, but you should set your own expectations in the longer term. That way you don't lose faith after a few weeks.

The truth is, you're going to experience some ups and downs. There'll be days or even weeks where you'll seem to be making progress, only to stall somewhere along the way before progress starts up again. Or you could seem to be making no progress at all and then suddenly something shifts and the pace picks up. You'll need to hang on for the ride.

The next two things are the need for some tech. Specifically video tech and a Google spreadsheet. The video tech will help monitor your dog and the Google spreadsheet will allow you to keep records so that you can accurately track progress across a variety of variables. The best video tech involves two devices such as phone and tablet of some sort with Zoom installed. That way you can open a Zoom meeting, leave one device in the area where your dog is and have the other on you for observation.

The Google spreadsheet is self-explanatory and will be the place that you record daily information regarding your program and its progress.

Next, you'll need to assess your dog. You can do this on your own or with the aid of a trainer. If you're working with our team at [Alpha Dog](#) you'll start with a video consultation. In fact, all of your work with a trainer will be virtual because not only is there no need for the trainer to see your dog in person, but because doing so could actually hinder the process. Why? Because dogs often behave differently with a trainer around than with just their owner.

In what follows, I'll assume that you've chosen to work with us and lay out the template for how we might work together.

## ***First Meeting***

During the first meeting you'll discuss all the variables impacting your situation and build a list of metrics by which we can evaluate it and measure progress. The main thing will be to determine whether your dog has the FOMO version of separation anxiety or the more serious version which this program is designed to address.

This may require some experimentation and the program that's ultimately designed might be a bit of a mash up of everything we've discussed so far. There's no 'one size fits all' training plan for separation anxiety. You'll need to design a program unique to your dog. I often use the analogy

of a Rubik's cube. Except, in this situation, instead of lining all the sides up to be the same, we have to line them up for the particular configuration of your dog's needs, predispositions, and so on.

If we decide that your dog has the FOMO version of separation anxiety, then we'll put together a program using the elements of the standard approach discussed above (pp. ?-?). But if we conclude that your dog is struggling with true anxiety, which we'll assume for the purposes of the rest of this section, then we'll continue to develop the program based on the template below.





## ***Second Meeting (and probably more)***

The next step will involve developing criteria for your initial series of comings and goings. Remember, the core of this program is getting your dog used to your comings and goings until she becomes less and less interested in them and can tolerate slowly increasing periods of time without you.

The most important concept to understand here is that of 'thresholds.' Through close observation, you'll need to assess how long before or after your departure your dog begins showing signs of separation related distress. Then you'll need to structure your early assignments so that your comings and goings stay beneath this threshold. Only with that pattern well-established will you have the foundation from which to move forward.

This requires close observation and, ideally, the trained eyes of a professional. You can also use the bullet list of behaviors provided above (p.5) to help in your evaluation. Once that's done, you'll either receive or develop on your own the week's assignments (stay tuned). And then you'll practice them five days a week for about thirty minutes each time. These periods of work will also incorporate the 'pre-departure cues' mentioned earlier (again, stay tuned).

Because of the importance of this steps and the number of variables to track, it's highly likely that one assessment won't be enough to thoroughly understand your dog's thresholds. You'll probably have to do a few

rehearsed absences and possibly a few reassessments in order to get the full picture of your dog's thresholds.

## ***Thresholds***

The most important thing to assess in the very beginning is at what point your dog begins to experience signs of distress. To that end, it's indispensable to use some video tech to help. You must be able to monitor your dog during your absence. As I mentioned above (p.?), you'll need two devices and a Zoom account ([free](#)) or something like it. If you're working with a trainer, you should have them participate in the first few sessions as you evaluate your dog's thresholds.

You'll also need to create an 'alone zone,' a place that's a source of comfort or security for your dog. It might be a crate (see p.??), a small room or a hallway cordoned off with baby gates. Or it might be your entire house. If the 'alone zone' is your entire house, I'd suggest closing as many doors to other rooms as possible, using baby gates to block hallways and staircases and, if your dog still has more room in which to roam than one Zoom device can handle, setting up a second one. The same applies if you're using a backyard or patio area. Again, you must be able to monitor your dog at all times.

With all that set up, you'll need to go through the various steps of your pre-departure routine – closing your laptop, opening your closet, putting on your shoes, grabbing the keys, opening your front door, closing it, starting the car, etc. – while

assiduously watching your dog. If you're on your own and can't really watch right at that time, be sure to record your Zoom session for analysis later. Keep a very close eye on the time and on your dog. You are looking for the earliest signs of distress – lip licking, pacing, whining and so on (p.?) – in order to help develop your baselines. This may start with your pre-departure routine. It can also take anywhere from a few seconds to a few minutes. And that could change depending on other factors, like how much exercise your dog has had, whether she's eaten or not, whether there are distressing sounds outside, what time it is and so on. Because there are so many variables involved, it's highly likely that you're going to have to do multiple threshold assessment sessions before settling on a plan. Keeping careful notes on all of this is extremely important for that reason.

### ***Taking Notes***

In addition to noting the times of the day and other influences like

exercise and outside stimulation, you want to be particularly precise about what happens immediately preceding and following your departure. Let's look at an example.

Yuzu is a two-year-old Corgi who reacts as follows when her owner leaves:

- **At 00:00 seconds you get up and begin your pre-departure routine by picking up your keys. Yuzu sits up, alert. She watches as you gather the rest of your things. Her mouth is closed, her ears are forward and her eyes are wide.**
- **At 1:12 you put Yuzu into her 'alone zone.'**
- **At 1:15 you walk out and close the door or gate.**
- **At 1:45 she sits by the door or gate, staring at it. This is your threshold! All exercises, for the time being, need to take place beneath this threshold.**
- **At 2:00 she begins lightly pawing at the door.**
- **At 2:30 she begins mildly whining.**

- **At 2:45 she begins anxiously pacing around the room.**
- **At 3:00 she returns to the door or gate and begins pawing at it.**
- **At 3:15 she begins whining, which escalates to barking by 3:30.**
- **At 3:45 she begins more vigorously pawing and scratching at the gate or door.**
- **At 4:00 the owner returns and Yuzu explodes with a spasm of joyful jumping.**
- **At 4:15 Yuzu returns to her spot on the sofa, relieved.**

Based on notes like this, which it might make sense to accumulate over a few sessions to be sure that we've properly identified the patterns, we can begin to build a plan.

### ***Building a Plan and Subsequent Meetings***

Based on this set of observations, you'd either design a training plan on your own and develop daily 'missions' from it or your trainer would do it for you and supply them. In either case, you'll need to keep very precise notes from each session and enter them into your Google spreadsheet. As notes are accumulated and bits of progress are made, the daily mission plans are adjusted accordingly to expand your dog's tolerance of growing increments of alone time.

In the example above, the first thing to do would be to separate the 'pre-departure' elements of this from the separation elements and deal with them individually. We'd start with the alone part first and insert the pre-departure routine





once we've made a little progress on that front.

The alone part starts at 1:15, when you walk out and close the door or gate. The first signs of distress come at 1:30, when she sits by the door staring at it anxiously. So, we need to begin our protocol beneath that threshold of anxiety. The importance of this cannot be overemphasized.

To begin, I'd start the session by just hanging out with the dog for a few minutes in order to be sure that she's fully relaxed before moving on to a short series of 'easy win warmups.' Because our window is only fifteen seconds between departure and the onset of anxiety, I'd do my warmups in one to two second increments. Always keep them very low relative to your dog's actual threshold of anxiety.<sup>2</sup>

Go out, close the door, count to one, return, ignore the dog, stand there for a few seconds until she's relaxed and repeat. But this time for two seconds. Then maybe one second. Then two or three. Be sure to keep notes on her responses by time (you can note everything later if you've recorded it, which will give you time stamps on everything). Tedious, yes. But important. Remember, we're trying to get your dog to become increasingly indifferent to your comings and goings.

It's important during your warmups not to approach your dog's threshold for anxiety. Remember, we're trying to get things going with easy wins that can begin to acclimate her to your pointless comings and goings until

she becomes indifferent to them.

The number of warm ups will change from day to day. On some days, you'll do six or seven and on others only two or three. Eventually, you won't need them anymore. Warmups should always only represent a very small fraction of your dog's actual threshold. And they should never be longer than sixty seconds, even if your dog's threshold is ten minutes or more.

With a few warmups under your belt, you can continue with slight increases in time in varying increments (again, keep notes on everything). In the above example the initial routine might go something like this:

- **Walk out, wait 6 seconds, return**
- **Hang out until your dog is relaxed and indifferent to you – 30 seconds.**
- **Walk out, wait 4 seconds, return.**
- **Hang out until your dog is relaxed and indifferent to you – 60 seconds.**
- **Walk out, wait 9 seconds, return.**
- **Hang out until your dog is relaxed and indifferent to you – 45 seconds.**
- **Walk out, wait 2 seconds, return.**
- **Hang out until your dog is relaxed and indifferent to you – 90 seconds.**
- **Walk out, wait 6 seconds, return**
- **Hang out until your dog is**

---

<sup>2</sup> There are some dogs for whom warmups may not be helpful. They may start show increasing signs of distress with successive warmups. In that case, it's better to scatter some absences randomly throughout your day with none of them containing warmups.



**relaxed and indifferent to you  
– 30 seconds.**

- **Walk out, wait 13 seconds, return.**
- **Hang out until your dog is relaxed and indifferent to you – 50 seconds.**
- **Walk out, wait 20 seconds, return.**

Repeat and keep repeating. But in subsequent repetitions, keep your turnaround time under ten seconds. DO NOT approach your threshold again.

As you build your program, there are some key points to bear in mind. First, the initial time duration from your baseline assessment, 30 seconds in our example, will be your starting target duration. However, during your initial sessions you want to keep your duration beneath that threshold, in this case around 20 seconds, until you get your dog accustomed to this routine. Once the routine is well established, perhaps five or six sessions in, then you should push your absence out to your target duration, in this case 30 seconds. You can then begin building from there.

Also, you should spend a little time with your dog between comings and goings and vary its duration anywhere between 30 and 90 seconds. As time goes on and your overall duration increases, you can begin decreasing the number of steps in your sessions.

As the program progresses, especially in the early stages, you want to be sure to approach your threshold only once. And even once you've got a good rhythm going and are beginning to make some headway, you want to be sure to not cross your threshold

too many times in a single session.

If you do, you risk a cumulative effect that could cause your dog to go over its threshold, which, in turn, can set you back.

You'll also note that we are randomizing the difficulty between steps. This prevents your dog from detecting patterns, something they're very good at and that we want to avoid. We're also going to use a lot of variability in our day-to-day criteria as we develop 'missions' for the same reason. We want to avoid pattern training and recognition.

***You'll also note that we are randomizing the difficulty between steps. This prevents your dog from detecting patterns, something they're very good at and that we want to avoid.***

As the program develops, you'll conduct missions five to seven days per week for a total of not more than twenty to thirty minutes a day (five a week is fine if it all feels like too much). And slowly, you'll start approaching and crossing the initial threshold or target duration, at which point our criteria for 'missions' will be adjusted upward. Cautiously.

That will look something like this. A few warm ups, then slowly building until we approach our target duration, then three or four in that range, pushing it out a bit here and there, and then a few more of shorter duration before



building to the last increment, which should be the longest and most challenging one, allowing us to end on a note of success with a peak performance. Most challenging my mean in terms of duration. But, if you're integrating pre-departure cues, it might also mean shortening the duration but adding some of those (more below). Also, between each increment, pause thirty to ninety seconds, staying where your dog can see you but without any engagement (ignore your dog) before departing again.

Once again, throughout all of it we want to maintain our randomization. And we want to resist the temptation to 'do just one more to see what happens.' Remember, we do not want to push your dog over its anxiety threshold. Take your little wins and watch them add up. Remember the analogy of compound interest.

In all of this, you should expect ups and downs. It's important to understand that the 'downs' are not failures but simply an expected part of behavior modification. If you couldn't hit your target on a particular session then either a) if your dog got close, try again the next day or b) if your dog was way off, lower your criteria the following day. Do not get hung up on achieving a straight line of progress. You'll only shoot yourself in the foot. Ironically, you'll move forward faster by going slower, being patient and expecting ups and downs. Pushing it will only set you back.

That brings us to the incorporation of pre-departure cues. As I mentioned earlier (p.??), common wisdom holds that these should be desensitized

independently of the structured alone time. But the thinking around this has changed. They should be integrated into the above routine so that the pre-departure cues actually become cues to safe, non-stressful absences.

Continuing with the above example, let's use the picking up of keys as the pre-departure cue. Let's say we've done a week or two of the protocol and we are seeing progress. Perhaps Yuzu is now able to hold out for a full two minutes before approaching her anxiety threshold. On your next session, what you'd do is pick up your keys, bring her into her area and then return to your same protocol. With one major exception. A basic principle that covers much of building reliability into training is that as you raise one criterion in difficulty, you temporarily lower others.

***With recalls or stays, as the level of distraction increases, the distance between you and your dog decreases and the frequency of treat rewards increases as well.***

For example, with recalls or stays, as the level of distraction increases, the distance between you and your dog decreases and the frequency of treat rewards increases as well. Only as your dog starts to improve with the higher level of difficulty would you raise the other criteria again as well – increasing distance and reducing the use of treats.



In our example, what that would mean is that if you've gotten your dog to two minutes before she approaches her anxiety threshold and you now want to introduce pre-departure cues, you'd drop the duration of your absence significantly for a short while until you've smoothly incorporated the new element into your routine. Then you can raise the original criteria back to where it was. And that shouldn't take too long. So, your gains aren't lost but supplemented and strengthened.

### ***Time and Timing***

There are a few factors under this category that are important to keep in mind. First, resist the temptation to increase mission difficulty every day. Throughout the whole program, maintaining variability both in timing and difficulty is key. On some days, difficulty will be lower and on others, higher. We want to prevent any kind of pattern training. The goal is to help your dog understand that any absence is a safe one, not necessarily that they're predictable. If it all becomes too predictable, then any departure from that predictability could again trigger anxiety.

In support of this point, a recent study found that dogs that had the highest percentage of successful trials were the ones who increased their departure duration the slowest and had the greatest number of short departures. That is not a small finding.

Also resist the temptation to increase the number of sessions per day and the length with which you work on them. Too much time spent on this can actually

have the opposite effect and end up sensitizing your dog to your impending absences rather than desensitizing them.

And bear in mind that progress is rarely in a straight line. If you graph your collected data out as you accumulate it, you'll find a sawtooth graph that slowly trends upward. The main thing is to pay attention to the trend far more than your daily ups and downs. And in most cases, after some time, you'll begin to find accelerating returns. Once you get your dog to the point where she can tolerate thirty minutes of alone time you can adjust your program to accommodate longer absences two to three times per week.

How long will all this take? It's hard to say but, as I suggested at the outset, you should think in terms of months, not weeks. Remember, you're dealing with deep-seated emotions related to anxiety. The best metaphor I've heard for this is grief, a profound and deeply uncomfortable emotion.

During the process of writing this little book I lost one my oldest and best friends suddenly and completely unexpectedly. In fact, he was a great designer and was going to lay out all this text into what you're holding in your hands right now. But suddenly, he's not here anymore. And I've spent several weeks dealing with completely unexpected waves of debilitating grief at completely random times for no particular reason. How long will it take me to get over this? I have no idea. But I will get over it. Or at least put it behind me.



The same with your dog. Fear of separation is a deeply uncomfortable emotion. How long it will take for her, with your help, to put it behind her is hard to say. But she will. If you stay the course.

### ***Miscellany***

There are a few ancillary issues worth mentioning as we bring all this to a conclusion. The first concerns the question of whether it would make sense to get a second dog to help the first deal with its separation anxiety.

On the whole, I think this is a terrible idea. For several reasons. First, for many dogs this won't have any effect. In 32 years of private training, I've only seen this work once. So, if you're seriously considering this option, I'd strongly recommend taking care of a friend's dog for a few days to see what impact this has on your dog. In most cases, it won't be much, if any.

But even if it is, I generally discourage people from getting a second dog as a solution to the problems of their first dog. This rarely ends up well and is a disservice to the new dog, who you're likely to view only as a means to an end rather than as a welcome companion in her own right. My strong recommendation is to only get a second dog if you really want a second dog as an end in itself, not as a means to some other end.

Two other outlier issues are worth mentioning. The first is geriatric onset separation anxiety. Like people, dogs, as they get older, weaker and possibly subject to cognitive decline, can feel vulnerable and afraid, which might make being away from you, their mainstay of comfort and security,

increasingly challenging. In that case, I'd suggest mitigating with meds in conjunction with your vet and putting mild version of the above programs in place.

The second is something called nocturnal separation anxiety, in which case, despite there being no signs of cognitive decline in your dog becomes hyper-vigilant at night. In this case, it's time for a vet visit to assess whether there's some kind of pain at play from things like tumors or arthritis. Those pains can be masked during the day (dogs are very good at masking pain in general) when your dog is distracted with other things but can rise to the forefront of her awareness at night in the absence of stimulation.

### ***Conclusion***

I've said several times throughout this book that the processes involved in resolving separation issues tend to be quite tedious. But they're also your only way out. You can certainly use the information in this little book to work out these issues on your own. But help is also available. And one form of it comes from our training team at [Alpha Dog University](#) in Mill Valley. Please feel free to contact us for an initial consultation to see if working with us would be a good fit for your and your dog.

If you decide to pursue the program on your own, know that diligence, patience and careful application have been routinely demonstrated to work. Hold this understanding close as you progress through the inevitable ups and downs involved with a program like this. There's light at the end of the tunnel and you're on your way to it.

# What is separation anxiety? And Does your Dog Have it?

“We’ll begin by looking at symptoms and attempting to assess whether these are a result of true separation anxiety or some other cause.

We’ll also address the issue, whatever its cause, by assessing its level of intensity and begin laying out a range of options that are short of the full-on separation anxiety protocols for severe cases outlined in the second half of this booklet.”

—Trainer Mike Wombacher



415-420-4768

[mwdoggonegood@gmail.com](mailto:mwdoggonegood@gmail.com)